

A man in a dark trench coat stands with his back to the camera, looking out over a futuristic city at night. The city features tall, illuminated skyscrapers and a large, multi-level structure with a central tower. The ground is wet and reflective, mirroring the city lights. In the background, there are cranes and a bridge over a body of water. The sky is dark with some clouds and a full moon.

36SEAS / FIRST MATE

THE AUTHOR FIELD GUIDE

# The book-to-launch *workbook.*

A practical plan for the book only you can make.

12 illustrated pages. Six stages. Checklists, creative briefs, and fillable worksheets to turn your next step into a finished task.

OUTLINE / WRITE / EDIT / DESIGN / PUBLISH / MARKET

36SEAS.COM

START HERE

# A route, not a race.

Find your current stage. Work toward its deliverable, then move forward.

## 01 Outline

A clear reader promise  
and a chapter map.

## 02 Write

A complete working draft,  
with gaps marked.

## 03 Edit

A revised manuscript  
and a resolved issue list.

## 04 Design

A focused cover brief  
and readable interior.

## 05 Publish

Checked files, metadata,  
and a chosen route.

## 06 Market

A reader message,  
assets, and outreach plan.

### HOW TO USE THIS WORKBOOK

Read one stage, make one decision, and produce one useful artifact. Return to earlier stages whenever the book changes.

## 01 / FOUNDATION

# Know the reader. Name the promise.

A book becomes easier to shape when you know who you want to reach.

1

## Choose one primary reader.

Describe their taste, situation, or question. Avoid "everyone who reads."

2

## State the experience you offer.

For fiction: an emotion, tension, or world. For nonfiction: an insight or useful change.

### EXAMPLE / FICTION POSITIONING

*For readers who love morally complicated crime stories, this book offers a tense investigation where every answer carries a personal cost.*

### MY PRIMARY READER

### MY ONE-SENTENCE PROMISE

**DONE WHEN** You can explain the book without summarizing every chapter.

## 01 / OUTLINE

# Build a spine before you draft.

Map the change your book delivers. Keep the structure flexible.

01

**OPEN**

A question or disruption

02

**DEEPEN**

Pressure and discovery

03

**TURN**

A costly decision

04

**LAND**

A changed  
understanding

**CHAPTER / SCENE CARD**

Give each chapter a job. If it does not move the story, build understanding, or prepare a payoff, rethink its place.

WHAT MUST CHANGE IN THIS CHAPTER?

WHAT QUESTION, OBSTACLE, OR EVIDENCE DRIVES IT?

WHAT MAKES THE READER CONTINUE?

02 / WRITE

# Make progress repeatable.

Schedule a small session you can keep, then protect the next one.

1

## Set the finish line.

Choose a scene, section, or time block. A realistic target beats a heroic one.

2

## Draft forward.

Mark gaps with [RESEARCH] or [FIX LATER]. Keep a separate parking lot for ideas.

3

## Leave a breadcrumb.

End with a note about the next scene or paragraph. Make restarting easier.

### YOUR WEEKLY WRITING PLAN

WHEN + WHAT I WILL FINISH

Session 1

WHEN + WHAT I WILL FINISH

Session 2

WHEN + WHAT I WILL FINISH

Session 3

#### A USEFUL MEASURE

Count completed sessions and scenes moved forward. Let consistency guide the plan.

03 / EDIT

# Revise from the outside in.

Fix the structure before polishing sentences that may not survive.

## 01 STRUCTURE

Does every section earn its place? Check stakes, sequence, pacing, and payoff.

## 02 CONTINUITY

Track names, dates, motivations, facts, and repeated ideas. Resolve contradictions.

## 03 LANGUAGE

Improve clarity, voice, dialogue, rhythm, and unnecessary repetition.

## 04 PROOF

Check spelling, punctuation, formatting, and final-file errors after layout.

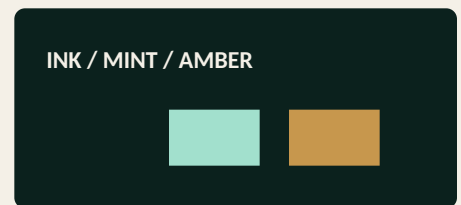
### MY THREE MOST IMPORTANT REVISION TASKS

All suggestions are proposals. Review them for voice, accuracy, and context. Outside readers or a professional editor can add another perspective.

## 04 / DESIGN

# Build a world readers recognize.

Use the cover, typography, and imagery to signal a coherent reading experience.



## MEAT WAGON / VISUAL STUDY

Published cover at left; temporary AI concept art at right. Study the shared atmosphere and contrast. A mood board guides a designer; final files still need review.

## THREE WORDS THAT DESCRIBE MY BOOK'S VISUAL WORLD

## MY COVER MUST SIGNAL / MUST AVOID



## 05 / PUBLISH

# Choose the route. Check the files.

Separate the publishing decision from the excitement of uploading a finished book.

## SELF-PUBLISH

You choose the platform, production team, budget, pricing, and release plan. You are responsible for checking every final file.

## SEEK A PUBLISHER

Research the fit and submission requirements. Prepare requested materials and track responses. Selection and timing vary.

## BEFORE YOU RELEASE

- ☐ Proof the final interior on screen and, for print, in a physical proof.
- ☐ Check the cover at thumbnail size and against current platform specs.
- ☐ Verify title, author name, description, categories, and other metadata.
- ☐ Confirm permissions for any third-party material you use.
- ☐ Review your chosen platform's current requirements and sales settings.

### 36SEAS + FIRST MATE

First Mate supports your author workflow. Human editing and other services are separate. Consideration by the 36Seas imprint is selective.



# Start the conversation early.

Create a reason to care, a place to learn more, and a clear next action.

## FOUNDATION

### Know your message.

Reuse your reader promise. Draft a short description and a one-line hook. Set up one book page and a permission-based email list.

## PRE-LAUNCH

### Prepare a small asset kit.

Gather a cover image, author bio, book description, sample excerpt, and verified purchase or signup links.

## LAUNCH

### Show up where readers are.

Choose relevant communities, personal outreach, and your own channels. Follow community rules and ask for honest feedback.

## FOLLOW-THROUGH

### Learn and keep showing up.

Record questions, clicks, replies, and sales where available. Repeat useful content and improve unclear messages.

Focus on actions you can sustain. A plan can improve readiness; it cannot promise sales, reviews, or bestseller status.

## YOUR LAUNCH ASSET KIT

# Write the invitation.

Make one clear message, then adapt it to each place your readers hear from you.

**A SIMPLE MESSAGE FRAME**

*For [reader], [book title] offers [experience or change].  
If you enjoy [relevant interest], start with [one clear next action].*

**MY ONE-LINE HOOK****MY SHORT READER INVITATION****MY ONE NEXT ACTION + WORKING LINK**

Before sharing: check the link, use an image you have permission to use, and keep the message specific. Never present invented endorsements or reviews as real.

## YOUR NEXT SEVEN DAYS

# One week. One finished deliverable.

Choose the stage that matters now. Give yourself a finish line you can recognize.

## MY CURRENT STAGE

## MY FINISHED DELIVERABLE

**DAY 1 / DECIDE**

Choose your priority and define done.

## MY TASK / TIME

**DAYS 2-3 / BUILD**

Protect two focused work sessions.

## MY TASK / TIME

**DAYS 4-5 / REVIEW**

Read, test, or ask for useful feedback.

## MY TASK / TIME

**DAY 6 / FINISH**

Resolve the most important open issue.

## MY TASK / TIME

**DAY 7 / RESET**

Save the work and choose the next step.

## MY TASK / TIME

KEEP THIS PAGE CLOSE

# Choose your next chapter.

Use this readiness check at every milestone. Complete the missing work before advancing.

- |                                  |                                                          |
|----------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| <input type="checkbox"/> OUTLINE | My reader promise and chapter map are clear.             |
| <input type="checkbox"/> WRITE   | My draft is complete, with open questions recorded.      |
| <input type="checkbox"/> EDIT    | My main structural and continuity issues are resolved.   |
| <input type="checkbox"/> DESIGN  | My visual brief, cover, and interior have been reviewed. |
| <input type="checkbox"/> PUBLISH | My route, final files, and metadata are checked.         |
| <input type="checkbox"/> MARKET  | My message, links, assets, and outreach plan are ready.  |

## PUT THE WORKBOOK TO WORK

### Write with First Mate

[app.36seas.com/signup](https://app.36seas.com/signup)

### Learn with us

[36seas.com/webinars](https://36seas.com/webinars)

Fillable fields work in compatible PDF readers. Save a local copy after completing them. Your worksheet answers stay in your PDF; they are not sent to 36Seas.